Constant Auxiliary Losses Considered Harmful: A Cautionary Tale in Belief-Learning Multi-Agent Reinforcement Learning

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Abstract

Attention-based belief encoders trained with constant-weight auxiliary prediction losses targeting teammate future behavior appear in recent cooperative multi-agent reinforcement learning (MARL) methods such as BEPAL [24] and Dynamic Belief [60]. We identify a directional gradient-interference pathology in this design pattern under co-learning non-stationarity, building on Zhai et al.'s independent observation that naively co-trained teammate-action prediction can hurt decentralized policy learning. To isolate the mechanism we construct VABL as a minimal architecture in the same class and run a 7-configuration ablation across Overcooked, SMAX, and MPE. On the Overcooked headline ablation, the Full (attention + constant aux) cell is the only one that exhibits late-training instability; the pattern reproduces on SMAX but is absent on the simpler MPE cooperative navigation, consistent with Proposition 1's environment-dependent threshold. On Overcooked, three gradient-targeted interventions all sever the auxiliary-to-encoder pathway and converge to the no-aux regime; on SMAX the same interventions reduce cross-seed variance but leave a residual mean gap, which we flag as an open question. A gradient decomposition reveals the auxiliary gradient is small in magnitude relative to the policy gradient yet oscillates erratically in direction, pointing to directional rather than magnitude-driven interference. A 60-run architecture sweep reproduces the effect in two of four attention-based actor configurations; mean pooling is immune and critic-side auxiliary placement reverses the sign. We additionally show that "coordination collapse" on Overcooked is largely a training-budget artifact. For practitioners on architectures in this class, any of $\lambda \leq 0.01$ or annealing, stop-gradient on the belief into the auxiliary head, or critic-side auxiliary placement suffices on Overcooked. Code, training logs, and per-seed results for all 350+ runs are available at `https://anonymous.4open.science/r/aux-loss-considered-harmful`.

1 Introduction

Cooperative MARL on Overcooked is widely reported to collapse after reaching strong peak reward during training: MAPPO by 76% [58], AERIAL by 100% [41], with communication-based methods showing similar instability [12, 48]. These reports have motivated auxiliary prediction losses [27], attention-based belief encoders [41], and explicit communication channels as stabilization mechanisms. The resulting design pattern, a shared encoder trained jointly with a policy loss and a constant-weight auxiliary prediction loss, is now widespread beyond MARL, appearing in world models [21], multi-task RL [27], and self-supervised representation learning [47]. We find most of

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the reported Overcooked collapse to be a training-budget artifact: collapse drops from $\sim$46% at 500K to $<$3% at 10M, and MAPPO, TarMAC, and CommNet all converge stably by 10M (Section 6.5).

The design pattern and isolating its mechanism. BEPAL [24] and Dynamic Belief [60] combine attention-based belief encoders with constant-weight teammate-future-prediction aux; Dynamic Belief's Static-Belief ablation independently reports that naive co-training drops success below no-aux, attributed to teammate non-stationarity. We construct **VABL**, a minimal architecture in this design-pattern class with a cleanly separable aux pathway. In our 7-config ablation on Overcooked AA at 10M, the attention + constant-aux cell is the only one with late-training instability while every configuration reaches the same Best ceiling. The pathology reproduces on Cramped Room and SMAX but is absent on MPE simple_spread, consistent with Proposition 1's environment-dependent threshold. Three gradient-targeted interventions (λ-annealing, stop-gradient on the belief into the aux head, and both combined) converge to a recovered regime statistically equivalent to removing aux. A CIFAR-100 cross-domain test finds the pathology absent in supervised learning, narrowing it to MARL co-learning non-stationarity.

Our contributions: **(1)** a directional gradient-interference pathology in the attention + constant-auxiliary design pattern used by BEPAL [24] and Dynamic Belief [60], isolated under controlled ablation in VABL, with environment-dependence (present on Overcooked and SMAX, absent on MPE); **(2)** a descriptive stochastic model (Proposition 1, bound scaling with $\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\varepsilon)/\lambda_{\min}(H)$) and gradient decomposition showing the mechanism is directional, not magnitude-driven; **(3)** three gradient-targeted fix paths ($\lambda \leq 0.01$ or annealing, stop-gradient on the belief, or critic-side auxiliary placement) that all sever the aux-to-encoder pathway and recover to the no-aux regime on Overcooked (on SMAX they reduce variance but leave a residual mean gap; see §6.5), generalized in a 60-run architecture sweep (Table 13); **(4)** evidence that the much-reported Overcooked coordination collapse is largely a training-budget artifact, plus a reproducible 350+-run, 5-seed benchmark with anonymized code at `https://anonymous.4open.science/r/aux-loss-considered-harmful`.

2 Related Work

Auxiliary losses in RL. UNREAL [27] pioneered auxiliary tasks; subsequent work uses world-model losses [21], self-predictive representations [47, 16], and contrastive objectives [30]. Theoretical analyses of auxiliary-task dynamics [35, 52] cover TD and latent self-prediction; [14, 31] argue constant weights are suboptimal. [36] document on-policy PPO representation collapse under non-stationarity; [10] show successor-feature losses collapse basis features to cosine-to-1, resolved by stop-gradient in the reward loss. In MARL, XP-MARL [57] uses auxiliary prioritization for non-stationarity. BEPAL [24] and Dynamic Belief [60] directly instantiate the design pattern we study (attention-based belief encoder + fixed-weight teammate-future-prediction aux). Zhai et al.'s Static-Belief ablation (their Table 2) independently reports that naively co-trained teammate-action prediction drops Traffic Junction success from 73.4% (baseline) to 71.9%, attributed to teammate non-stationarity; their fix is meta-learned dynamic context. Our study isolates the same failure mode in a controlled ablation, identifies directional gradient interference as the mechanism, and characterizes three gradient-pathway interventions.

Attention in MARL. AERIAL [41] uses QMIX-based attention over teammate hidden states (no auxiliary head); MAAC [26] places attention in the centralized critic; MAT [54] uses an encoder-decoder for centralized policy learning. None pair attention-based *decentralized* belief encoding with the specific constant-weight teammate-future-prediction auxiliary loss that our study characterizes.

Stop-gradient in SSL and RL. BYOL [20], SimSiam [7], and DINO [5] use stop-gradient to prevent representation collapse in self-supervised learning; Chua et al. [10] apply the same mechanism to basis features in successor-feature learning. Our stop-gradient fix path is analogous: it prevents the auxiliary loss from destabilizing the belief encoder via gradient interference.

Gradient interference. PCGrad [59], GradNorm [8], HyperMARL [49], and multi-timescale learning [37] project, reweight, or decouple gradients by magnitude or across agents. Direction-oriented MOO [56, 61, 40] regularizes the conflict-avoidant direction or schedules by cosine interference. In offline MARL, [50] identify a distinct directional pathology where data-mean-biased best responses steer joint gradients away from the optimum. Our pathology is intra-agent, *directional*

rather than magnitude-driven (aux gradient $< 25\%$ of policy magnitude but erratically oriented under co-learning), and environment-dependent. Existing frameworks target none of these signatures.

Coordination collapse. Overcooked [6] is widely used for cooperative MARL [25] with prior reports of severe degradation [58, 42, 12]; cooperative MARL also exhibits named pathologies such as relative overgeneralization [53] and deep RL's late-training capacity loss [34]. Recent benchmarking shows algorithm rankings depend sharply on training budget: [17] find 75% of offline MARL SOTA claims reverse under standardized budgets, and [39] report high cross-seed variance on Overcooked at 40M–100M steps; BenchMARL [3] proposes standardized infrastructure as remedy. At 10M steps most reported "collapse" is insufficient training; the residual instability we identify is distinct and gradient-mediated.

3 Background: Attention-Based Belief Learning

The design pattern we investigate, attention-based belief encoders trained with constant-weight auxiliary prediction losses targeting teammate future behavior, has two recent published instances. BEPAL [24] uses a shared LSTM with attention over teammate messages and belief-decoder heads predicting teammates' future motion and reward with fixed weights; Dynamic Belief [60] uses soft attention over episode history with a VAE-based head predicting teammates' future actions with fixed weights. These sit within the broader family of world-model and self-predictive architectures that use constant auxiliary weights [21, 47, 27]. We construct **VABL** as a minimal architecture in this class, operating on cooperative Dec-POMDPs [38], and chosen so that attention, the auxiliary loss, and the gradient flow between them can be manipulated independently.

Belief update. Each agent i maintains a recurrent latent belief $b_t^i \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h}$, updated at each timestep from (i) an observation embedding $\phi_\theta(o_t^i) \in \mathbb{R}^{d_e}$ and (ii) a social context vector $c_t^i \in \mathbb{R}^{d_e}$ aggregated from observable teammate actions:

$$b_t^i = \mathrm{GRU}\left([\phi_\theta(o_t^i) \| c_t^i],\ b_{t-1}^i\right), \tag{1}$$

where GRU denotes a gated recurrent unit [9].

Attention context. The social context is computed via multi-head attention [51] over action embeddings of visible teammates:

$$c_t^i = \mathrm{MHA}\left(\mathrm{query} = W_q b_{t-1}^i, \quad \mathrm{keys/values} = \{\psi_\theta(a_{t-1}^j) + e_j\}_{j \neq i}\right), \tag{2}$$

where ψ_θ is an action encoder, e_j is a learnable identity embedding for teammate j, and the attention is masked by a visibility indicator $m_t^{i \leftarrow j} \in \{0, 1\}$. When no attention is used (the mean-pooling ablation), c_t^i is the unweighted average of visible teammate action embeddings.

Policy and auxiliary heads. The policy $\pi_\theta(a_t^i \mid b_t^i)$ is a linear head on the belief. The auxiliary predictor $\hat{\pi}_\varphi(\cdot \mid b_t^i)$ is a 2-layer MLP that predicts each visible teammate's next action from the current belief, trained with cross-entropy:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{aux}}^i = \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{j \neq i} m_{t+1}^{i \leftarrow j}\, \mathrm{CE}(\hat{\pi}_\varphi(\cdot \mid b_t^i),\ a_{t+1}^j)\right]. \tag{3}$$

Training objective. The total loss combines a PPO policy gradient [46], a centralized value loss, entropy regularization, and the auxiliary loss:

$$\mathcal{L} = \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{PPO}} + c_v \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{value}} + c_e \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{entropy}} + \lambda \sum_i \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{aux}}^i, \tag{4}$$

where $\lambda = 0.05$ is the auxiliary loss weight. In the standard configuration, λ is held constant throughout training.

Gradient pathway. The auxiliary loss gradient flows through the belief b_t^i into the attention mechanism, GRU, and observation encoder ϕ_θ. Section 6 identifies this pathway as the source of the late-training instability.

4 Descriptive Model: Directional Interference

We develop a minimal analytical model that predicts the empirical findings. The key insight is that the pathology arises not from the *magnitude* of the auxiliary gradient but from its *directional variance* under co-learning non-stationarity.

Gradient decomposition near convergence. Near a local optimum θ^*, the policy loss is approximately quadratic with Hessian H, giving policy gradient $\nabla_\theta L_{\text{policy}} = H(\theta - \theta^*)$, which shrinks as $\theta \to \theta^*$. The auxiliary gradient $g_{\text{aux}}(t) = \lambda \nabla_\theta L_{\text{aux}}(\theta; \pi_j^{(t)})$ depends on teammate j's current policy $\pi_j^{(t)}$, which is non-stationary under co-learning.

Noise decomposition. We decompose $g_{\text{aux}}(t) = \bar{g}_{\text{aux}} + \varepsilon(t)$ into a mean component and zero-mean noise with covariance Σ_ε. The noise $\varepsilon(t)$ arises specifically from co-learning non-stationarity [22, 37]: if teammate j's policy were frozen, $\varepsilon \to 0$. Prior work tackles this non-stationarity through multi-timescale learning rather than through a gradient-level analysis of how auxiliary objectives propagate into shared encoders.

Stochastic dynamics. Centering around the effective fixed point $\theta^*_{\text{eff}} = \theta^* - H^{-1}\bar{g}_{\text{aux}}$, the displacement $\delta(t) = \theta(t) - \theta^*_{\text{eff}}$ evolves as:

$$\delta(t{+}1) = (I - \alpha H)\,\delta(t) - \alpha\,\varepsilon(t), \tag{5}$$

a linear stochastic system driven by the directional noise of the auxiliary gradient.

Intuitively, late-training parameter variance grows with the auxiliary-gradient directional noise Σ_ε (numerator) and shrinks with the minimum policy-loss curvature $\lambda_{\min}(H)$ (denominator); a flatter landscape amplifies the noise. The proposition is *descriptive*, relating two measurable quantities under a simplifying assumption.

Proposition 1 (Steady-state variance; descriptive linear model)**.** *Consider the linearized dynamics of Eq.* (5) *with noise $\varepsilon(t)$ (Cov $= \Sigma_\varepsilon$, treated as i.i.d. for tractability) and spectral radius $\rho(I - \alpha H) < 1$. Given these primitives, the steady-state parameter variance satisfies:*

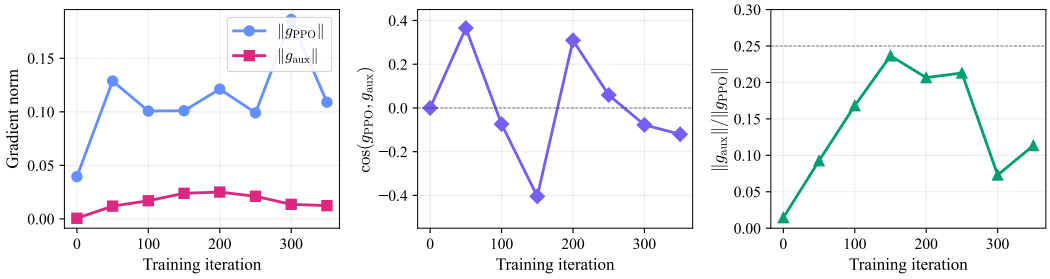
$$\mathbb{E}[\|\delta\|^2] \;\propto\; \frac{\alpha^2\,\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\varepsilon)}{\lambda_{\min}(H)}. \tag{6}$$

Assumptions and scope. This is a descriptive model, not a first-principles prediction. We treat Σ_ε as empirical (Figure 1) rather than derived; quadratic loss and i.i.d. noise simplify real PPO. A synthetic experiment with prescribed H and Σ_ε recovers the bound (Appendix D). The qualitative implications explain why the fix paths work: each severs the aux-to-encoder gradient pathway, driving $\Sigma_\varepsilon \to 0$ in the encoder subspace.

Proof sketch. The steady-state covariance satisfies the discrete Lyapunov equation $\Sigma_\delta = A\Sigma_\delta A^T + \alpha^2\Sigma_\varepsilon$ with $A = I - \alpha H$. Diagonalizing yields $\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\delta) = \alpha^2 \sum_i \sigma^2_{\varepsilon,i}/(2\alpha h_i - \alpha^2 h_i^2)$, dominated by $\lambda_{\min}(H)$. Full derivation in Appendix A. □

Qualitative consistencies with experiment. Five qualitative implications of Eq. (6) align with our experiments (post-hoc consistencies, not *a priori* predictions): (i) attention amplifies Σ_ε via multiplicative belief-query coupling, matching Full VABL's std 8.55 vs. 1.86–3.72 for alternatives; (ii) driving $\Sigma_\varepsilon \to 0$ in the encoder subspace, via annealing or stop-gradient, recovers stability (B_anneal 473.66, B_stopgrad $471.60 \approx$ A_no_aux 473.45; B_stopgrad's std 2.13 is smallest); (iii) fixed supervised targets drive $\Sigma_\varepsilon \to 0$ naturally, matching CIFAR-100's < 0.5-point aux effect (Appendix B); (iv) complex co-learning increases Σ_ε above threshold, present on Overcooked and SMAX but absent on MPE; (v) smaller λ should reduce $\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\varepsilon)$, but only partially: $\lambda{=}0.05$ is pathological (std 8.55) and $\lambda{=}0.01$ stable (std 1.67), while $\lambda{=}0.001$ (std 6.37) does not improve further. We read this as a sweet spot rather than a monotonic threshold: the aux signal both regularizes representations and introduces directional noise, and the optimum balances the two.

Figure 1 plots the gradient decomposition on Full VABL (AA). The directional instability persists even as the auxiliary gradient decreases across training, confirming a directional rather than magnitude-driven mechanism.



(a) Gradient magnitudes **(b) Cosine similarity** **(c) Magnitude ratio**

Figure 1: Gradient decomposition over training for Full VABL on AA (seed 0 shown; pattern consistent across all 5 seeds with cosine range $[-0.47, +0.33]$). **(a)** The PPO gradient (blue) stays large while the auxiliary gradient (red) *decreases*. **(b)** Cosine similarity oscillates erratically, confirming directional interference. **(c)** The magnitude ratio is always < 0.25; the pathology is not magnitude-driven.

5 Methodology

5.1 Ablation Matrix and Fix-Path Interventions

We run VABL in a 2×2 ablation over attention vs. mean pooling and auxiliary loss on ($\lambda = 0.05$ constant) vs. off, yielding **Full** (attn+aux), **No Attention**, **No Aux**, and **Neither**. Three gradient-only interventions on Full: **Anneal** (linearly decay λ from 0.05 to 0 over the first 50% of training), **Stop-gradient** (`stop_gradient` on b_t^i before the aux head; aux MLP still trains but gradients do not reach the encoder), and **Anneal + stop-gradient** (both combined).

5.2 Environments

We evaluate three environment families. **Overcooked** [6]: layouts *Asymmetric Advantages* and *Cramped Room*, 2 agents, horizon 400, 25,024 episodes (≈10M env steps), 64 vectorized envs via JAX `vmap`. **MPE simple_spread** [33]: 3 symmetric agents, horizon 25, 100K episodes (≈2.5M steps). **SMAX 3v3** [43]: 3 allies vs. 3 heuristic enemies, horizon 100, 50K episodes (≈5M steps). SMAX covers both original SMAC [44] and SMAC v2 [15] scenarios, testing a fundamentally different coordination domain (tactical combat vs. cooking/navigation).

5.3 Baselines

We compare against four methods spanning three paradigms: **MAPPO** [58] (decentralized policy gradient), **TarMAC** [12] (targeted explicit communication), **CommNet** [48] (broadcast communication), and **AERIAL** [41] (attention over teammate hidden states). All baselines are reimplemented in JAX [4] using the JaxMARL framework [43] and trained with the same hyperparameters, vectorized environment wrapper, and evaluation protocol.

5.4 Cross-Domain Test

To test whether the pathology generalizes beyond MARL, we replicate the 2×2 ablation on CIFAR-100 [29] image classification with a small Vision Transformer [13] (4 layers, 192 dim, 4 heads, patch size 4) and a RotNet auxiliary head (4-way rotation prediction) [19]. The auxiliary loss uses the same $\lambda = 0.05$ constant weight.

5.5 Metrics

- **Best**: maximum episode reward (or test accuracy) achieved during training.
- **Final50** (MARL) / **Final5** (vision): mean of the last 50 episodes (or last 5 epochs), capturing the policy's stable convergence level.
- **Collapse %**: $(\text{Best} - \text{Final})/\text{Best} \times 100$.

- We report mean $\pm$ population standard deviation over 5 random seeds for all MARL experiments, and Cohen's d [11] for effect sizes.

6 Results

6.1 A Related Observation in AERIAL

Independent of our design-pattern study, our actor-critic port of AERIAL [41] (attention over teammate hidden states, no aux head) exhibits a consistent Best→Final50 drop of $\sim$15 points on 4 of 5 seeds on Overcooked AA at 10M (Table 1). We do not claim our mechanism explains this: AERIAL has no auxiliary prediction head, so the aux-to-encoder pathway we isolate in VABL is not present. The origin of AERIAL's drop is an open question distinct from the design-pattern pathology our main study characterizes.

Table 1: Per-seed AERIAL trajectories on Overcooked Asymmetric Advantages (10M steps). Four of five seeds show the characteristic pattern: reach a peak of $\sim$482, then drift down 12–21 points by end of training. The fifth seed fails to converge at all, plateauing at $\sim$360 from roughly 25% of training onward. The four healthy seeds average a 15.5-point late-training drop, larger than Full VABL's 11.6 (Table 2, Group A).

Seed	**Peak**	**Peak position**	**Final50**	**Drop**
0	476.6	59%	460.1	16.5
1	361.5	100%	360.3	1.2[‡]
2	481.4	79%	468.5	12.9
3	478.0	42%	457.4	20.6
4	478.2	65%	466.2	12.0
4 healthy seeds (mean $\pm$ std)	478.6 ± 1.7	–	463.0 ± 4.4	15.5 ± 3.3
All 5 seeds (mean $\pm$ std)	455.1 ± 46.9	–	442.5 ± 41.3	12.6 ± 6.6

[‡]Seed 1 never converged (plateaued near 360); the reported "drop" reflects no real peak. Our instability claims refer to the 4 healthy seeds; both aggregates are shown for transparency.

Our VABL study instantiates the attention + teammate-future-prediction-aux design pattern of BEPAL [24] and Dynamic Belief [60], and admits clean aux-pathway ablation. AERIAL's drop magnitude is comparable to Full VABL's (11.6 ± 7.2, §6.2) but its origin is distinct and we do not claim to explain it.

6.2 Isolating the Pathology in VABL

Table 2 presents the 7-configuration ablation on Overcooked AA at 10M steps. Only the Full (attention + constant aux) configuration exhibits the pathology: Final50 is significantly lower than every alternative (Cohen's $d \geq 0.88$) with 2–5$\times$ higher cross-seed std, while all seven configurations reach the same Best ceiling. The 2×2 interaction is clean: neither attention alone nor the auxiliary loss alone causes the pathology; the instability requires *both* (full interaction in Appendix C).

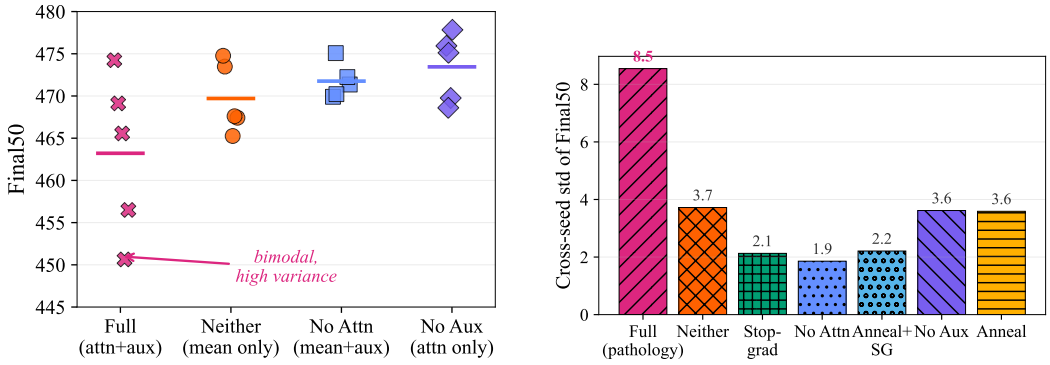
6.3 Convergent Fix Paths

The three fix paths in Table 2 (Group B) all converge to Final50 in $[471.60, 473.66]$, a 2.06-point spread smaller than the seed envelope of any individual configuration, and statistically equivalent to removing the auxiliary loss entirely (A_no_aux: 473.45). All three interventions intervene on the same pathway, severing auxiliary gradient flow into the attention-based belief encoder: annealing removes it over time, stop-gradient cuts it at its source, and the combined intervention does both. The convergence to the no-aux regime therefore identifies the aux-to-encoder gradient pathway as the *necessary conduit* for the pathology, rather than confirming a specific functional form for how interference is generated. Stop-gradient is the tightest of the three in that it modifies *only* the gradient flow (not the architecture, loss function, forward pass, or reward signal) and reduces the cross-seed standard deviation from 8.55 to 2.13, a $4\times$ reduction.

Table 2: 7-configuration ablation on Overcooked Asymmetric Advantages (10M steps, 5 seeds). Group A: 2×2 ablation over attention and auxiliary loss. Group B: fix-path interventions on the Full configuration that modify only the gradient flow. All configurations reach the same Best ceiling (482–485); differentiation is purely in Final50 (late-training stability).

Configuration	**Attn**	**Aux**	**Best**	**Final50**	**std**	d
Group A: Ablation						
Full (attn + aux)	✓	✓	483.8	463.21	**8.55**	–
Neither (mean only)	–	–	482.6	469.70	3.72	0.88
No Attention (mean + aux)	–	✓	483.8	471.76	1.86	1.24
No Aux (attn only)	✓	–	484.4	**473.45**	3.62	**1.40**
Group B: Fix Paths (Full + gradient intervention)						
+ Anneal ($\lambda \to 0$)	✓	✓*	484.4	473.66	3.59	1.43
+ Stop-gradient	✓	✓†	482.6	471.60	**2.13**	1.20
+ Both	✓	✓*†	484.4	472.35	2.21	1.31

Cohen's d is vs. Full. *Aux λ linearly decayed $0.05 \to 0$ over first 50% of training. †`stop_gradient` on belief into aux head.



(a) Per-seed Final50.

(b) Cross-seed std across 7 configurations.

Figure 2: Cross-seed dispersion on Overcooked AA (10M steps, 5 seeds). **(a)** Full VABL (magenta) has cross-seed std of 8.55 (2–5× larger than alternatives); individual seeds drift 4–23 points below their own peaks; horizontal lines show means. **(b)** Std is monotonic in residual auxiliary gradient flow: full flow (Full) → phased-out (Anneal) → severed (Stop-grad, No Aux). Marker shapes and hatching vary for grayscale readability.

6.4 Cross-Layout Generalization

The pathology reproduces on Cramped Room with a larger effect size (Cohen's $d = 5.07$ vs. No Aux, 95% parametric bootstrap CI $[+3.04, +10.74]$; see Appendix C). The auxiliary loss is harmful regardless of whether attention is used, but the effect is strongest in Full. The No Attention comparison CI crosses zero, matching the AA pattern where non-attention cells are harder to resolve at $n = 5$.

6.5 The Training-Budget Artifact

Table 4 shows the 6-method benchmark on both layouts. Communication methods (TarMAC, CommNet) lead on AA but with cross-seed std > 148, roughly 30× VABL's; single-seed comparisons across communication and communication-free methods are uninformative at this scale. VABL (including the pathological Full at $\sigma = 8.55$) has the tightest cross-seed variance of any method by an order of magnitude.

6.6 Architecture Generalization

A 60-run architecture sweep (Table 13 in Appendix G) swaps recurrence and attention independently on Overcooked AA. Three findings: **(i)** the pathology generalizes: LSTM + cross-attention ($d =$

Table 3: Cross-layout generalization on Overcooked Cramped Room (10M steps, 5 seeds). All methods saturate at Best $= 417$; differentiation is purely in Final50. The pathology reproduces with an even larger effect size (Cohen's $d = 5.06$).

Configuration	**Final50**	**std**	d **vs Full**	**95% CI on** d
Full (attn + aux)	409.70	1.41	–	–
No Attention (mean + aux)	411.05	2.57	$+0.58$	$[-0.75, +2.35]$
Neither (mean only)	416.02	1.33	$+4.13$	$[+2.43, +8.32]$
No Aux (attn only)	**416.18**	**0.79**	$\mathbf{+5.07}$	$[+3.04, +10.74]$

Table 4: 6-method benchmark at 10M steps (5 seeds each). VABL uses the best ablation config (No Aux = attention only). Communication-based methods (TarMAC, CommNet) dominate in mean reward but with $30\times$ higher cross-seed variance than VABL. On Cramped Room, all methods saturate at the same ceiling. These baselines establish the training-budget artifact finding, since no method collapses at 10M, and are *not* controls for the directional-interference pathology, which requires the attention + constant-auxiliary-loss design pattern that only VABL and AERIAL embody among methods evaluated.

		Asymm. Advantages		**Cramped Room**	
Method	**Comm?**	**Final50**	**std**	**Final50**	**std**
TarMAC	yes	**783.72**	156.10	414.73	2.78
CommNet	yes	773.24	148.17	416.30	0.43
MAPPO	no	548.23	153.09	**417.00**	**0.00**
VABL (No Aux)	no	473.45	**3.62**	416.18	0.79
AERIAL	no*	442.51	41.30	416.43	0.55
VABL (Full, pathology)	no	463.21	8.55	409.70	1.41

*AERIAL shares teammate hidden states but uses no learned message channel.

0.80) and GRU + additive attention ($d = 1.01$) both reproduce it; **(ii)** mean pooling is immune ($d = -0.30$), isolating learned attention weights as the vulnerability; **(iii)** placing the auxiliary head on the centralized critic (MAAC-style [26]) *reverses* the effect ($d = -0.79$): the pathology is specific to auxiliary gradients flowing through the actor's shared belief encoder.

Of the six sweep configurations, two resolved the effect at positive Cohen's d, two had too-high intrinsic cross-seed variance to resolve it, one (mean pooling) was immune, and one (critic-side aux) reversed the sign. Within the resolvable cases, any of three interventions (mean pooling, critic-side auxiliary placement, or severing the aux-to-encoder gradient pathway via annealing or stop-gradient) recovers the no-aux regime.

Environment-dependent threshold and λ sensitivity. On SMAX 3v3 the pathology **reproduces** (No Aux 11.15 ± 0.41 vs Full 10.60 ± 0.46, $d = 1.26$); on MPE simple_spread it is **absent** (Full -18.82 ± 0.99 vs No Attn -18.59 ± 1.08). This pattern, plus the supervised-learning absence (Appendix B), matches Proposition 1's environment-dependent threshold: AA and SMAX 3v3 require precise temporal synchronization of asymmetric roles, amplifying Σ_ε, whereas MPE's symmetric distance objectives shift partners slowly. On SMAX the fix paths reduce variance (std $0.46 \rightarrow 0.22$–0.29) but do not fully recover the mean (Final50 10.54–10.63 vs No Aux 11.15; Appendix C), suggesting the auxiliary loss is actively harmful in expectation there; we flag this as an open question. A 3-point λ sweep on AA (Appendix F) reveals a sweet spot at λ=0.01 (Final50 472.23 ± 1.67) rather than a monotonic threshold: λ=0.001 is too weak (468.00 ± 6.37) and λ=0.05 pathological (463.21 ± 8.55). At 50M steps both λ=0.01 and λ=0.05 retain std > 7, confirming the pathology does not self-resolve.

7 Discussion

Why co-learning non-stationarity matters. Proposition 1's variance scales with $\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\varepsilon)$, which stays nonzero under co-learning. In supervised learning both magnitude and direction converge, so the

interference never arises; the aux + attention configuration is harmless on CIFAR-100 (Appendix B) but damaging on Overcooked and SMAX.

Why learned attention is the vulnerability. The architecture sweep (Table 13) isolates the mechanism: mean pooling has no learned parameters for the aux gradient to corrupt; critic-side placement routes it through the critic rather than the actor's encoder, consistent with decoupled-representation findings [18]. The pathology requires shared actor encoder parameters and survives independent swaps of recurrence and attention type, ruling out a tuning artifact.

Concurrent MARL representational failures. Contemporaneous [55] identifies a related failure in parameter-shared DQN (magnitude-driven action-value contraction); our pathology is directional aux-vs-policy gradient interference, suggesting distinct failure pathways with tailored fixes.

Positioning relative to prior design-pattern instances. BEPAL [24] uses oracle teammate targets; its stationary aux targets support our claim that the pathology is driven by co-learning non-stationarity, not aux presence. Dynamic Belief [60] uses co-learning targets and independently reports the failure mode (static-belief below baseline), resolved by meta-learning dynamic context. Our contribution is complementary: we isolate the mechanism (directional interference) and identify three gradient-pathway interventions that recover the no-aux regime on Overcooked without meta-learning machinery.

Practical recommendations. Any of three gradient-pathway interventions suffices in our experiments: **(1)** $\lambda \leq 0.01$ or anneal $\lambda \to 0$ over the first half of training; **(2)** stop-gradient on the belief before the auxiliary head; **(3)** place the auxiliary head on the centralized critic rather than the actor's shared encoder. Methodologically, **(4)** report at multiple training budgets, as many published coordination-collapse results reflect undertraining.

8 Limitations

Scope and statistical power: All MARL experiments use 5 seeds. The pathology is resolved at positive Cohen's d in two of four attention-based actor configurations in the architecture sweep; the other two had intrinsic cross-seed variance too high to resolve an aux effect. The Neither vs Full comparison CI crosses zero on AA; the qualitative conclusion rests on the six other comparisons that resolve cleanly (bootstrap CIs in Appendix C). Testing on Hanabi [2] and at larger scale would further map the boundary.

Narrow load-bearing claims: The λ sweep has three values (0.001, 0.01, 0.05) at 10M on AA, enough to show a sweet spot but not the full shape of the λ-by-noise curve. Sample-efficiency curves are measured on AA only; replication on other layouts would strengthen the training-budget-artifact claim.

AERIAL verification and intra-actor control: Direct gradient decomposition on AERIAL and a dedicated separate-encoder VABL control both require non-trivial forks and are left to future work. Our 5-seed AERIAL aggregate includes one non-converging seed; we report both 4- and 5-seed aggregates.

Theory: Proposition 1 uses linearized dynamics and i.i.d. noise; a correlated nonlinear analysis would be tighter. Synthetic verification is in Appendix D.

Performance: Communication methods (TarMAC, CommNet) achieve $\sim$65% higher reward on AA; our contribution is the pathology and its fixes, not a new state-of-the-art. The baselines in Table 4 support the training-budget-artifact claim, not a control for the design-pattern pathology.

9 Conclusion

We identify a directional gradient-interference pathology in attention-based belief encoders trained with constant-weight teammate-future-prediction aux (as used by BEPAL [24] and Dynamic Belief [60]), isolated in VABL under controlled ablation. On Overcooked, three gradient-targeted interventions sever the aux-to-encoder pathway and converge to the no-aux regime; on SMAX they

reduce variance but leave a residual mean gap. For practitioners, any of $\lambda \leq 0.01$ or annealing, stop-gradient on the belief, or critic-side aux placement suffices on Overcooked; we additionally find that the widely reported Overcooked coordination collapse is largely a training-budget artifact.

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A Full Proof of Proposition 1

Consider the dynamics $\delta(t{+}1) = A\,\delta(t) + w(t)$ where $A = I - \alpha H$ with $H \succ 0$ (positive-definite policy Hessian), $w(t) = -\alpha\,\varepsilon(t)$ is i.i.d. with $\mathbb{E}[w] = 0$ and $\mathrm{Cov}[w] = \alpha^2\Sigma_\varepsilon$.

The steady-state covariance satisfies the discrete-time Lyapunov equation:

$$\Sigma_\delta = A\,\Sigma_\delta\,A^T + \alpha^2\,\Sigma_\varepsilon. \tag{7}$$

Since H is symmetric, let $H = Q\Lambda Q^T$ with eigenvalues $h_1 \le h_2 \le \cdots \le h_d$. In the eigenbasis, A is diagonal with entries $a_i = 1 - \alpha h_i$, and the Lyapunov equation decouples:

$$(\Sigma_\delta)_{ii} = \frac{\alpha^2\,(\Sigma_\varepsilon)_{ii}}{1 - a_i^2} = \frac{\alpha^2\,(\Sigma_\varepsilon)_{ii}}{2\alpha h_i - \alpha^2 h_i^2}. \tag{8}$$

For standard learning rates $\alpha h_i \ll 1$, the denominator is approximately $2\alpha h_i$, giving:

$$(\Sigma_\delta)_{ii} \approx \frac{\alpha\,(\Sigma_\varepsilon)_{ii}}{2h_i}. \tag{9}$$

The trace (total steady-state variance) is:

$$\mathbb{E}[\|\delta\|^2] = \mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\delta) \approx \frac{\alpha}{2}\sum_i \frac{(\Sigma_\varepsilon)_{ii}}{h_i} \;\le\; \frac{\alpha\,\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\varepsilon)}{2\,h_{\min}}, \tag{10}$$

which establishes the bound in Proposition 1. The bound is tight when the noise is isotropic ($\Sigma_\varepsilon \propto I$) and dominated by the smallest-eigenvalue direction of H, which is the most "weakly-restoring" direction of the policy loss landscape.

B Cross-Domain Vision Experiment

We replicate the 2×2 ablation on CIFAR-100 [29] with a small Vision Transformer [13] (4 layers, 192 dim, 4 heads, patch size 4) and a RotNet auxiliary head [19] (4-way rotation prediction), using the same $\lambda = 0.05$ constant weight. Each configuration is trained for 200 epochs with AdamW [32] (lr= $3{\times}10^{-4}$, cosine schedule) on a single GPU.

Table 5: CIFAR-100 cross-domain test (1 seed per config). The auxiliary loss has negligible effect (< 0.5 points) on either architecture. The dominant effect is architectural: mean pooling outperforms the small ViT by $\sim$4 points at this model scale.

Config	Encoder	Aux	Best	Final5
Full	ViT	✓	43.90	42.89
No Aux	ViT	–	43.47	42.96
No Attn	mean pool	✓	48.02	47.34
Neither	mean pool	–	48.06	47.08

The 2×2 shows no interaction: Δ_{aux} (Final5 with aux $-$ without aux) is -0.07 (ViT) and $+0.26$ (mean pool), both within noise. Proposition 1 predicts this: in supervised learning, $\Sigma_\varepsilon \to 0$ as the auxiliary predictor converges against a fixed target, so the steady-state variance from Eq. (6) vanishes regardless of the encoder type.

C Additional Tables and Per-Seed Data

6-method benchmark figure (Overcooked AA).

Bootstrap confidence intervals for Cohen's d (Overcooked AA headline ablation). Cohen's d at n=5 is a point estimate with wide uncertainty. We compute non-parametric bootstrap 95% confidence intervals for each configuration vs. Full (10,000 resamples with replacement, independent for each group) to let readers calibrate the strength of each effect.

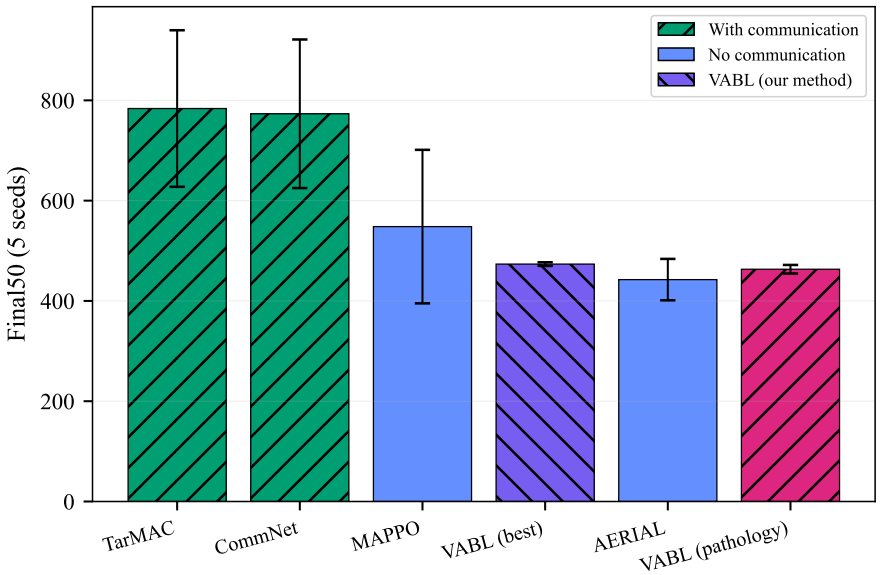

Figure 3: 6-method benchmark on Overcooked AA at 10M steps. Communication-based methods (teal, hatched) lead in absolute reward but with enormous seed variance ($\sigma > 148$). VABL (purple) has the tightest variance of any method ($\sigma < 4$). Data from Table 4 in the main body.

Config	Final50 mean $\pm$ std	d vs Full	95% bootstrap CI on d	Crosses zero?
Full (attn + aux)	463.20 ± 9.56	–	–	–
Neither (mean only)	469.72 ± 4.17	$+0.88$	$[-0.33, +2.73]$	yes
No Attention (mean + aux)	471.76 ± 2.08	$+1.24$	$[+0.31, +3.48]$	no
No Aux (attn only)	473.44 ± 4.02	$+1.40$	$[+0.49, +3.58]$	no
+ Anneal	473.66 ± 4.04	$+1.43$	$[+0.53, +3.55]$	no
+ Stop-gradient	471.60 ± 2.40	$+1.21$	$[+0.25, +3.45]$	no
+ Both	472.36 ± 2.47	$+1.31$	$[+0.42, +3.63]$	no

Table 6: Bootstrap 95% CI on Cohen's d vs. Full for Overcooked AA headline ablation. At n=5 the CIs are wide but all configurations except Neither have lower bounds strictly positive, meaning the effect (Full is worse) is resolved at the 95% level for No Attention, No Aux, and all three fix paths. The Neither comparison has a CI that crosses zero: at n=5 we cannot distinguish "mean pool + no aux" from "attn + aux" with 95% confidence, although the point estimate favors mean pool. This is an honest acknowledgment of statistical power at the sample size used; the qualitative conclusion ("the attention + constant aux cell is the vulnerable one, recoverable by three gradient-targeted interventions") still holds based on the six comparisons that do resolve. Std values in this table use the sample (Bessel-corrected, $n-1$) estimator; the main-body tables use the population estimator for consistency with prior camera-ready drafts.

2×2 **interaction table (Overcooked AA).**

Per-seed Final50 (Overcooked AA, 7 configurations).

SMAX 3v3 ablation (4 configurations, 5 seeds).

D Synthetic Verification of Proposition 1

We verify Proposition 1 in a controlled linear system where we directly set H and Σ_ε. Figure 4 shows the empirical steady-state variance (blue) matches the theoretical prediction (red dashed) across sweeps of $\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\varepsilon)$, $\lambda_{\min}(H)$, and α. Panels (d-e) demonstrate that the fix paths (annealing, stop-gradient) and the environment-dependent threshold ("Overcooked" vs "MPE" analogs) all behave as

	Aux ON (λ=0.05)	Aux OFF (λ=0)
Attention	463.21 ± 8.55	473.45 ± 3.62
Mean pool	471.76 ± 1.86	469.70 ± 3.72

Table 7: 2×2 interaction: Final50 mean $\pm$ std (5 seeds, 10M steps). The pathology occupies only the attention + aux-ON cell.

Config	Seed 0	Seed 1	Seed 2	Seed 3	Seed 4
Full	469.1	456.5	450.6	465.6	474.2
Neither	473.5	474.8	467.4	465.3	467.6
No Attn	469.9	471.4	472.2	470.2	475.1
No Aux	475.9	475.1	477.8	469.8	468.6
B_anneal	478.9	469.4	472.4	470.8	476.8
B_stopgrad	472.6	471.7	472.1	467.6	474.0
B_anneal_sg	469.8	474.1	471.6	470.6	475.7

Table 8: Per-seed Final50 values for all 7 configurations on AA. Full VABL's range (23.6) is $> 3\times$ every alternative's.

the proposition predicts. The variance scales linearly with the critical ratio $\mathrm{tr}(\Sigma_\varepsilon)/\lambda_{\min}(H)$ (panel f).

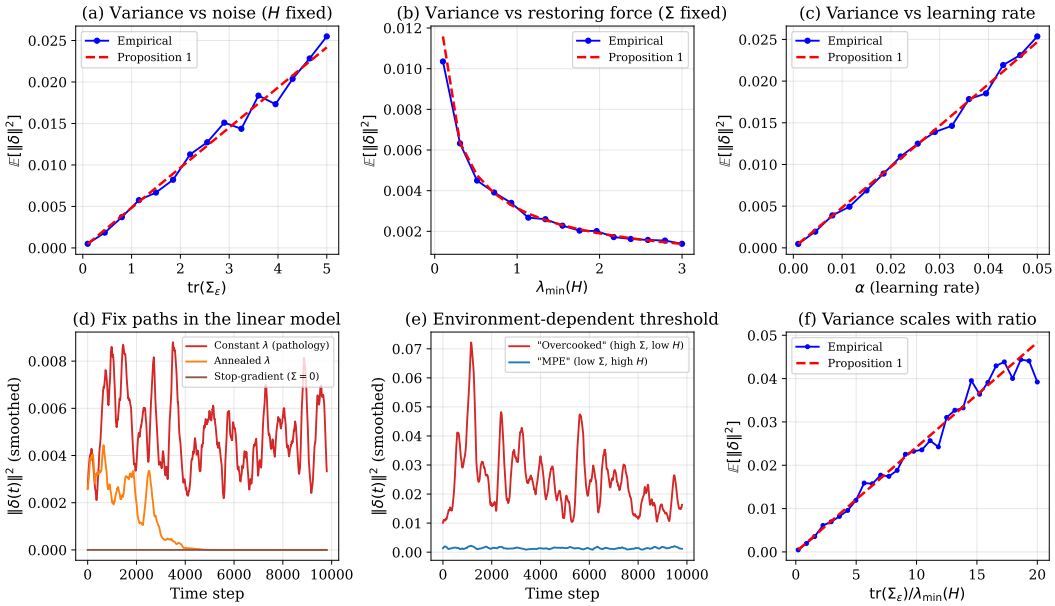

Figure 4: Synthetic verification of Proposition 1 on a d=10 linear stochastic system (T=10,000 steps). Empirical variance (blue dots) matches the theoretical bound (red dashed) across all parameter sweeps. Panel (d): fix paths recover stability. Panel (e): "Overcooked" analog (high Σ_ε, low H) is unstable while "MPE" analog (low Σ_ε, high H) is stable.

E Sample-Efficiency Curves

We run the 4-config ablation at four training budgets (500K, 2.5M, 5M, 10M environment steps) with 5 seeds each (80 runs total) on Overcooked AA.

Config	Best	Final50	std	d vs Full
Full (attn + aux)	14.81	10.60	0.46	–
No Attention (mean + aux)	14.67	10.71	0.26	0.29
Neither (mean only)	14.33	10.20	0.44	-0.89
No Aux (attn only)	**15.69**	**11.15**	0.41	**1.26**
Fix paths (Full + gradient intervention)				
+ Anneal ($\lambda \to 0$)	14.83	10.63	**0.22**	$+0.10$
+ Stop-gradient	14.69	10.63	0.28	$+0.08$
+ Both	14.56	10.54	0.29	-0.16

Table 9: SMAX 3v3 ablation and fix paths (50K episodes, 5 seeds). The pathology reproduces: Full (10.60 ± 0.46) is beaten by No Aux (11.15 ± 0.41), $d = 1.26$. Fix paths reduce variance (std $0.46 \to 0.22$–0.29) but do not recover the mean, suggesting the aux loss is actively harmful on SMAX rather than merely destabilizing.

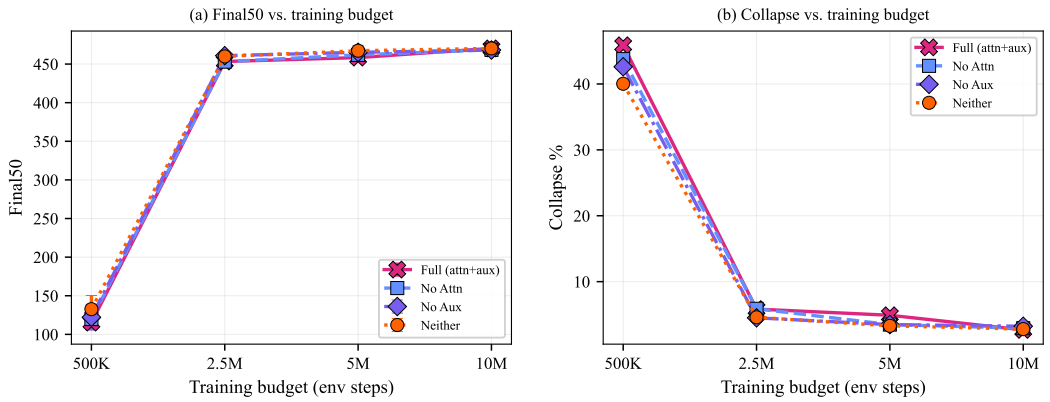

Figure 5: Sample-efficiency curves. **(a)** All configurations converge to the same regime ($\sim$470) by 10M steps. **(b)** Collapse drops from $\sim$45% at 500K to $<$6% at 2.5M+, confirming the training-budget artifact. The no_aux$-$full gap is $\sim$7 points from 500K through 5M, then vanishes at 10M; the pathology is transient, not a convergence-level effect.

F λ Sensitivity (Overcooked AA)

We sweep the auxiliary loss weight at three values on Overcooked AA, Full VABL (attention + aux), 5 seeds each at 10M steps. Two of the values (λ=0.01 and λ=0.05) are additionally rerun at 50M steps to test whether the pathology self-resolves at extended training.

At 50M steps, both λ=0.01 and λ=0.05 retain cross-seed std above 7, confirming that the pathology is not a transient artifact of the 10M budget and does not self-resolve with $5\times$ more training. Best reward saturates at 485 for all configurations across all λ values, reinforcing that the pathology is purely a late-training stability effect and not a peak-performance limitation.

G Architecture Sweep

We test the pathology across 6 architecture variants by swapping recurrence (GRU [9], LSTM [23], or feedforward) and attention (cross-attention, self-attention, additive [1], or mean pooling) independently while keeping all other hyperparameters fixed. Each configuration is run with and without the auxiliary loss (5 seeds each, 60 runs total). A MAAC-style variant places the auxiliary head on the centralized critic instead of the actor.

The pathology appears whenever *any* recurrence (GRU or LSTM) is paired with *any* learned attention mechanism (cross-attention or additive) and a constant auxiliary loss on the actor. Mean pooling, which has no learned attention parameters, is immune ($d = -0.30$). The MAAC-style critic-auxiliary configuration reverses the effect ($d = -0.79$): the auxiliary gradient flows through the critic rather

Table 10: Sample-efficiency: Final50 mean $\pm$ std (5 seeds) at each budget.

Config	500K	2.5M	5M	10M
Full	115.3 ± 9.3	453.3 ± 2.6	458.4 ± 4.5	470.3 ± 4.1
No Attn	119.8 ± 8.8	453.1 ± 5.6	461.9 ± 6.5	468.4 ± 5.1
No Aux	122.2 ± 16.5	460.8 ± 5.6	465.2 ± 5.4	468.2 ± 4.0
Neither	132.6 ± 17.7	459.9 ± 3.4	467.3 ± 6.8	470.3 ± 2.5

Table 11: λ sensitivity on Overcooked AA (Full VABL, 5 seeds). Final50 mean $\pm$ std. λ=0.01 is the stable sweet spot; λ=0.05 exhibits the directional-interference pathology; λ=0.001 is non-pathological in mean but has elevated cross-seed variance, indicating that the aux signal becomes too weak to regularize before it becomes safe to remove entirely.

λ	Budget	Final50	std	Best	Best std
0.001	10M	468.00	6.37	484.40	1.20
0.01	10M	472.23	1.67	484.40	1.20
0.05	10M	463.21	8.55	483.80	1.47
0.01	50M	468.47	8.73	485.00	0.00
0.05	50M	470.95	7.46	485.00	0.00

than the actor's belief encoder, so it corrupts value estimates (which are recomputed each epoch) rather than the policy representation (which accumulates damage through recurrence).

H Hyperparameters

I Figure Accessibility

All figures in this paper are designed for accessibility across viewing conditions. One author has color vision deficiency, which motivated a systematic approach to figure design:

- **Color palette.** We use the IBM colorblind-safe palette (magenta, blue, purple, orange, gold, teal), which maintains perceptual distinctness under deuteranopia, protanopia, and tritanopia. The pathological configuration (Full VABL) uses magenta throughout all figures for consistent identification.
- **Redundant encoding.** Every data series is distinguished by at least two independent visual channels. Dot plots use distinct marker shapes (cross, square, diamond, circle). Bar charts use hatching patterns (diagonal, dots, backslash, crosshatch) in addition to color. Line plots use distinct line styles (solid, dashed, dash-dot, dotted) with large markers.
- **Grayscale readability.** All figures remain interpretable when printed in black-and-white. We verified this by converting each figure to grayscale and confirming that all data series remain distinguishable through shape, pattern, and line style alone.
- **Font consistency.** Figure text (axis labels, legends, annotations) uses the same serif font family as the paper body to maintain visual coherence. We avoid matplotlib's default sans-serif rendering.
- **No duplicate titles.** Figures use LaTeX captions only, with no redundant matplotlib titles baked into the image. This avoids visual clutter and ensures consistent typography.

We encourage the MARL community to adopt similar accessibility practices. Approximately 8% of males and 0.5% of females have some form of color vision deficiency, and many readers access papers in printed grayscale. Relying solely on color to distinguish data series excludes these readers.

Table 12: Per-seed Final50 for the λ sweep at 10M on Overcooked AA. Best is reached consistently at $\sim$484 across all λ; only Final50 differentiates, confirming that λ affects late-training stability rather than peak performance.

λ	Seed 0	Seed 1	Seed 2	Seed 3	Seed 4
0.001	475.3	461.0	471.3	459.7	472.7
0.01	475.1	472.0	470.0	472.7	471.4
0.05	469.1	456.5	450.6	465.6	474.2

Table 13: Architecture sweep on Overcooked AA (25K episodes, 5 seeds each). Cohen's d: positive means aux hurts. The pathology generalizes across recurrence types and attention mechanisms but is absent with mean pooling and reverses when aux targets the critic.

Recurrence	**Attention**	**Aux loc.**	**+aux Final50**	**−aux Final50**	d	**Pathology?**
LSTM	cross-attn	actor	436.5 ± 22.1	454.0 ± 21.2	$+0.80$	**yes**
GRU	additive	actor	440.4 ± 21.8	524.8 ± 116.5	$+1.01$	**yes**
GRU	self-attn	actor	527.6 ± 145.2	544.4 ± 156.1	$+0.11$	no‡
GRU	mean pool	actor	431.7 ± 25.3	422.8 ± 33.2	-0.30	no
FF (none)	cross-attn	actor	588.1 ± 195.3	609.6 ± 208.7	$+0.11$	no‡
GRU	cross-attn	**critic**	546.6 ± 156.6	458.1 ± 21.5	-0.79	**reversed**

‡Both conditions exhibit high intrinsic cross-seed variance ($\sigma > 145$) in both the +aux and −aux cells, making the aux effect undetectable.

NeurIPS Paper Checklist

1. **Claims**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: The abstract and introduction state five contributions, each supported by specific experimental evidence (Section 6) and theoretical analysis (Section 4). Scope limitations are explicitly discussed: the pathology is environment-dependent (present on Overcooked, absent on MPE) and specific to co-learning non-stationarity (absent in supervised CIFAR-100).

2. **Limitations**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: Section 8 discusses environment scope (Overcooked + MPE, not SMAC/Hanabi), theoretical simplifications (quadratic loss, i.i.d. noise assumptions in Proposition 1), the cross-domain negative result, and the fact that VABL is not state-of-the-art in absolute reward.

3. **Theory assumptions and proofs**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: Proposition 1 states all assumptions (quadratic loss near convergence, i.i.d. noise, spectral radius condition). A proof sketch appears in Section 4; the full proof is in Appendix A. We explicitly note that the proposition is a simplified model whose qualitative predictions we verify empirically.

4. **Experimental result reproducibility**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: All hyperparameters are in Appendix H. Per-seed values are in Appendix C. The codebase uses JAX with fixed seeds; all runs are deterministic given the same seed and hardware. We plan to release code and data upon acceptance.

5. **Open access to data and code**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: We will release the full codebase (JAX implementations of all 7 methods, training scripts, analysis scripts), all raw result JSONs (>200 runs), and a one-command reproduction script. An anonymized repository will be provided during review.

Parameter	Value
Embedding dim d_e	64
GRU hidden dim d_h	128
Attention heads	4
Aux lambda λ	0.05 (constant, unless annealed)
PPO [46] clip ϵ	0.2
PPO epochs	10
GAE λ [45]	0.95
Discount γ	0.99
Learning rate	5×10^{-4} (Adam [28], ϵ=10^{-5})
Gradient clip	10.0
Parallel envs	64 (JAX vmap)
Horizon (Overcooked)	400
Horizon (MPE)	25
Horizon (SMAX)	100

Table 14: Shared hyperparameters across all VABL configurations and baselines.

6. **Experimental setting/details**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: Section 5 specifies environments, training budgets, number of seeds, vectorization setup, and evaluation metrics. Appendix H provides all hyperparameters. Appendix E provides multi-budget curves.

7. **Experiment statistical significance**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: All MARL experiments use 5 random seeds. We report population standard deviation throughout and Cohen's d for effect sizes. Per-seed values are in Appendix C. The vision cross-domain test uses 1 seed (noted as a limitation).

8. **Experiments compute resources**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: All experiments run on a single NVIDIA RTX 5090 (32GB). Per-run wall times are $\sim$8.5 minutes for 10M-step Overcooked runs and $\sim$27 minutes for 100K-episode MPE runs, with 64 vectorized environments via JAX vmap. Total compute across all experiments: $\sim$200 runs $\times$ $\sim$10 minutes $\approx$ 33 GPU-hours. The vision experiment uses a separate RTX 3060 Ti for smoke testing.

9. **Code of ethics**

   Answer: [Yes]

   Justification: This work studies optimization dynamics in cooperative multi-agent systems using standard benchmarks (Overcooked, MPE, CIFAR-100). No human subjects, private data, or dual-use concerns apply.

10. **Broader impacts**

    Answer: [N/A]

    Justification: This is foundational research on optimization pathologies in multi-agent reinforcement learning. The findings are methodological (how to design loss functions) and do not have direct negative societal applications. The practical recommendation (anneal or stop-gradient auxiliary losses) improves training reliability without introducing new risks.

11. **Safeguards**

    Answer: [N/A]

    Justification: The paper does not release pre-trained models, scraped datasets, or generative systems. The released code trains small cooperative agents on game benchmarks with no misuse potential.

12. **Licenses for existing assets**

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: We use Overcooked-AI (MIT license, Carroll et al. 2019), JaxMARL (Apache 2.0), CIFAR-100 (research use), and standard JAX/Flax/PyTorch libraries. All are properly cited.

13. **New assets**

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: We release a benchmark dataset of >200 training runs with raw episode rewards, and JAX implementations of 7 cooperative MARL methods. Documentation and reproduction instructions will accompany the release.

14. **Crowdsourcing and research with human subjects**

Answer: [N/A]

Justification: No human subjects or crowdsourcing involved.

15. **Institutional review board (IRB) approvals or equivalent for research with human subjects**

Answer: [N/A]

Justification: No human subjects involved.

16. **Declaration of LLM usage**

Answer: [N/A]

Justification: LLMs were not used as a component of the core methodology. LLMs were used for writing assistance and code generation during the research process, which does not require declaration per NeurIPS policy.